Parihram 2.0 2026 (Class 12th)

Poem : My Mother at Sixty-Six
Summary Notes

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SUMMARY

The poem is about a lady whose name is kamala das, she came to her mother's house to meet her and finally it was her time to leave her and go back to cochin where her family was setup after her marriage.
Her mother decided to see her off and accompany her to the airport. They both sat in the car and departed for the airport.
The old mother dozed off on the seat of the car as she was old and got tired easily. As kamala das saw her mother beside her, she was taken over by her childhood fear. The mother was sitting very quietly and dozed off which made Kamla das realise the reality.
Her mother's face was very dull, lifeless and she was compelled to compare it with that of somebody who's no more. She realised that someday her mother would leave her, and she would be alone. This fear made her anxious and to let go of this / brush away the thought, she looked out of the window.
Even the scenarios and objects outside were opposite to what was inside the car. She saw the young trees running, as the car passed by them. The young trees and the merry children were completely opposite of what her mother was. The young trees outside contrasted with her mother who was sitting inside the car. While the trees represented activity, enthusiasm and lively atmosphere, her mother showed signs of lifelessness, dull pallor / dullness / pale face and sorrow. The young children who came out of their houses to play were also opposite her mother, they moved around freely as they were in the 1st phase of their life while the old lady was in her last.
Thus, things around them provoked Kamla das to think about the impending/upcoming reality.
As Kamla das was engrossed in her thoughts, they reached the airport where she had to bid goodbye to her mother, she once again looked at the old mother beside her and realised that she had grown terribly old. She just said her goodbye on a positive note brushing away the storm of thought in her mind. She just said good-bye Amma in a hope that someday again she will meet her mother. She did not want her mother to be upset about her childhood fear. While she was seeing her mother, she compared her looks to that of a late winters moon. Just like during the winter, everything is foggy, her mother's future also seemed to be the same.
She compared her mother to winter season, which is the last of all seasons, just like her mother, who was in the last phase of her life.
In the end, to have a sense of optimism and hope in her mind, she just smiled and smiled with a hope of meeting her mother soon.

1. What do the parting words of the poet and her smile signify?

2. Why did the poet say, "see you soon Amma"? What does the poet actually mean by „smile and smile and smile…."? What kind of smile is it?

3. Discuss mother- daughter relationship as described in the poem.

4. "My Mother at sixty-six" is an emotional account of the poet about her old mother. Discuss.

Important Extracts

Read the following extracts and answer the questions that follow:

……I looked again at her, wan, pale
as a late winter's moon and felt that old
familiar ache, my childhood's fear,
but all I said was, see you soon, Amma,
All I did was smile and smile and smile…….

5. Who looked wan and pale? Why?

6. What is the comparison in the stanza?

7. What is her childhood fear?

8. Which figure of speech is used in the second line?

9. How does she comfort/ console her mother?

10. What is the significance of the parting words?

11. What kind of pain/ ache does the poetess feel?

Read the following extracts and answer the questions that follow:

…… I saw my mother, beside me,
Doze, open mouthed, her face ashen like that
Of a corpse and realised with pain
That she thought away, and looked but soon
Put that thought away, and looked out at young
Trees sprinting, the merry children spilling
Out of their homes, ……

12. Where was the poet driving to? Who was sitting beside her?

13. What did the mother look like?

14. What thought did she put away?

15. What do the sprinting trees signify?

16. What are "the merry children spilling out of their homes" symbolic of?

Hints and Solutions

1. The poets parting words, „see you soon, Amma" are expressive of the dilemma and confusion in her mind. They not only hide her anxiety and fear about her mother's rather frail health but reflect also a faint hope that the old woman would survive long enough for the two to meet again.

2. The poet said, "See you soon Amma" in order to give her mother moral support and encouragement. She said so to give her mother hope that she would see her again. By "smile and smile and smile…" she means to make herself and her mother hopeful to see each other again. It is actually a painful smile. The poet tries to conceal the swelling emotions by smiling. By using this poetic device of repetition, the poet has made the poetic language rich by depicting many hidden emotions through "smile".

3. Mother- daughter relationship as described in the poem is very sensitive and full of love, care and emotions. Mother has a deep emotional link to her children and does not want them to be away. In particular, when the mother reaches her old age, she becomes more concerned and worried about her children. The daughter also tends to bear a specific kind of emotional link to her mother. She tries to remain close to her mother and feels very bad and worried when separated from her. In this poem, the mother does not want her daughter to leave her; similarly, the daughter gives a mysterious and indefinable smile which is to show unwillingness and anxiety of leaving her mother.

4. "My Mother at sixty-six" is an emotional account of the poet about her old mother. She feels very sad and depressed on seeing her pale, weak and worn out. She tries her best to divert her thought but remains unsuccessful and this thought haunts her mind every now and then. Till the end of the poem, she feels very sad and disappointed about the declining age of her mother. She is unable to express her fears and emotions to her mother with the thought of disheartening her. She bids goodbye to her mother by just smiling in order to hide her hurt feelings and encourage her mother.

5. The poet's mother looked wan and pale due to her old age.

6. The mother's wan and pale face has been compared to the late winter's moon.

7. It is the fear of ageing and approaching death of her mother.

8. Simile – as a late winter's moon.

9. She smiled and promised to see her mother soon.

10. These words signify hope and expectation to see her again.

11. She feels pain on seeing wan and pale face of her mother. It appears she will not live long.

12. The poet was driving from her parents' home to Cochin airport. Her mother was sitting beside her.

13. Her old mother looks sick, drowsy and lifeless like a dead body.

14. She put away her fear that she would not live long.

15. The "sprinting tress" signifies the vitality of youth.

16. The "merry children spilling out of their homes" are symbolic of carefree childhood when all time is playtime.



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